Purshotamdas persuaded the nationalist leader and public figure, Srinavasa Sastri, to become the President[2] of the Currency League. This was done to lend credibility to the agitation and counter the government's charge of it being merely an agitation by the capitalists. The British policy of divide and rule was evident when they tried to create divisions based on region and class by describing Purshotamdas's Minute of dissent as pro-Bombay, pro-capital, and anti-labour.[3] Purshotamdas consistently highlighted the view that their stand would in fact benefit the agricultural class. He also pointed out that 'giants' like Dadabhai Naoroji, R.C. Dutt, and Sir Dinshaw Wacha had intervened in the currency question and demanded a lower ratio with G.K. Gokhale being the first to challenge in the Imperial Legislature the financial and currency policy of the government a quarter of a century ago.[4]

It has been argued that capitalists like Purshotamdas were 'genuinely operating in the economic sphere as members of the nationalist intelligentsia.'[5] The 'attempt was to develop a hegemonic anti-imperialist economic ideology (albeit from a bourgeoisie developmental perspective) and not merely agitate for their narrow class demands.'[6] The capitalists had realized that it was the former approach which would help them acquire the nation's sanction behind their demands while the latter would merely project them as selfseekers. Interested as the capitalists were in their own welfare, their positions did 'largely represent national interests in a colonial context and the tallest nationalist leaders freely accepted their advice and views and sought their help in negotiating complex financial matters.'[7]

An attempt was made to educate leaders like Gandhi and Motilal Nehru in major contemporary economic issues. Purshotamdas strongly urged the Mahatma to take up the currency question for the sake of the poor agriculturist and thought it a misfortune that a person such as Gandhi should be as 'ignorant …as [a] scholar in a primary school.' (This was how Gandhi had described himself.)[8] Motilal Nehru sought assistance from an 'expert' like Purshotamdas for drafting with B.F. Madon's help, material on the economic hold the government had acquired in the last five to six years in currency, trade, and banking. Motilal planned to incorporate this in his presidential address at the Indian National Congress. Motilal, for his part, helped secure the support of the Swarajists for Purshotamdas when the Currency Bill was being debated, and which as we shall see later, the nationalists lost by a narrow margin of only three votes.